



FAWZAN HUSAIN

SONIA GANDHI AND MANMOHAN (LEFT) IN MUMBAI; R.R. PATIL, VILASRAO DESHMUKH, (ABOVE) AND SHIVRAJ PATIL IN EXIT MODE



SIPRA DAS

This was in stark contrast to the swiftness with which the party dealt with the fallout at the Centre. And that was solely due to Sonia, and, perhaps indirectly, her two children, and even her late mother-in-law. At the start of the cwc meeting, the most talked about issue was Priyanka Gandhi Vadhera's comments when she recalled her grandmother Indira Gandhi's "strong and decisive rule". Shortly after, a grim-faced Sonia walked in and announced, "The time for intent and passing resolutions is over. It is now time for decisive action and determined leadership." The tone was set, albeit belatedly, for the first head to roll. It belonged to Shivraj, the Union home minister who presided over the deadliest terror strikes in India's history with supreme incompetence. Even with Mumbai on fire, he dithered over his resignation but the Congress chief, who had been awake two nights in a row monitoring the events in Mumbai, was in no mood to relent.

Sonia was reflecting the mood in the cwc meet which made two demands—accountability and action against Pakistan. Rahul Gandhi, not known for saying much at such meetings, said, "*Koi hamare ghar mein ghus aye, thappad mare, isse sharmnak cheez aur kya hogi* (Someone enters our house, slaps us. What can be more shameful)?" Clearly, decisive action was the only option and the appointment of the action-oriented finance minister P. Chidambaram in place of the effete Shivraj is just the first step in the semantics of image rebuilding. Chidambaram is al-

A BELEAGUERED CONGRESS WANTS ACCOUNTABILITY AND ACTION AGAINST PAKISTAN FROM ITS LEADERSHIP.

chief minister Vilasrao Deshmukh did himself no favour by taking a tour of the Taj Hotel, after it was cleared of terrorists, along with his actor son Riteish and film director Ram Gopal Varma.

After the NCP sacked Patil, there was pressure on the Congress to replace Deshmukh. In a game of one-upmanship he claimed that he had resigned much earlier, along with home minister Shivraj Patil at the Congress Working Committee (cwc) meeting. Yet the party waited for four days before finally accepting his resignation. The excuse for inaction was the same that was given to Congress Chief Sonia Gandhi when she wanted to axe Shivraj after the Delhi blasts—lack of consensus on the replacement. Even in an hour of crisis, political brinkmanship reigned supreme.

ready making the right noises, looking to plug the loopholes in the existing terror laws. But as a normally supportive ally Lalu Prasad Yadav pointed out, is it too little too late? A lot needs to be done if the Congress has to restore its credibility before the general elections. Indeed so jingoistic was the mood that some even suggested military action against Pakistan.

The war against terror in general and specific action against Pakistan is now firmly on the Congress agenda. That is one reason why Foreign Minister Pranab Mukherjee was not shifted to home, even though there was a suggestion to bring in Dr Karan Singh as his replacement. Manmohan took over the ministry he once headed with distinction, finance. As a Congress